

Nurlan Utesov

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SUMMARY

Ph.D. candidate in Agricultural and Applied Economics at the University of Wisconsin–Madison, on the 2026–27 job market. Research fields: political economy, economic history, development and public economics, with a second line of work in industrial organization. My research is about problems of asymmetric information that arise in agriculture, the taxation of farms and the adoption of technology, studied mostly in an autocratic environment, where the state taxes farms and allocates technology through delegated agents. The job market paper measures, on the digitized accounts of Soviet collective farms, what a uniform land tax cost in excess deaths and expulsions and divides the cost between the state's information constraint and its agents' incentive constraint. The applied line studies technology adoption and contracts in U.S. agricultural supply chains.

EDUCATION

2020 – present Ph.D. Candidate, Agricultural and Applied Economics, **University of Wisconsin–Madison**
(expected 2027)

Advisors: Paul Castañeda Dower, Paul Mitchell, Guanming Shi

2017 – 2019 M.A. in Economics, **New Economic School**, Moscow

2011 – 2015 B.Sc. in Economics, **Moscow State University**

WORKING PAPERS

- *Power Without Information: The Human Cost of Uniform Land Taxation in Subsistence Agriculture* [Job Market Paper], draft September 2026
- *Taxing What the State Could See: The Design of Soviet Grain Procurement and the Famine of 1933*, draft September 2026
- *Victory over Peasantry: Extractive Institutions and the Big Push* (with Vladimir Gimpelson and Paul Castañeda Dower), draft March 2026
- *Technology, Contracts, and Coordination: Modernizing Agricultural Supply Chains in Wisconsin Potatoes*, draft October 2025

WORK IN PROGRESS

- *Who Was Removed: Repression and the Collective Farm in the Urals, 1930–1934* (data collection in progress: a registry of 79,356 persons dispossessed or disenfranchised, matched to the 1928 settlement census and to the farm accounts)

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

- 2026: Summer Workshop in the Economic History and Historical Political Economy of Russia (University of Chicago Center in Paris) — *Building and Destroying: Technology, Repression, and Productivity Under Extractive Institutions*

- 2025: Central Asian Economics Conference (Almaty, Kazakhstan) — *Relational Contracts and Technology Adoption in Agricultural Supply Chains*
- 2024: Agricultural and Applied Economics Association (AAEA) Annual Meeting (New Orleans, LA) — *Local Premium Quality Foods and Marketing Contracts in the Wisconsin Fresh Potato Market*
- 2023: Economic History Association (EHA) Annual Meeting (Philadelphia, PA) — *Victory Over Village: Failed State-Led Agricultural Modernization*

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Graduate Research Assistant, UW-Madison 2020 – present
Digitization of Soviet farm-level accounts and statistical surveys (collective-farm annual reports, TsUNKhU dynamic surveys, district handbooks); supply chain modernization in the Wisconsin potato industry.

Research Assistant, Université de Namur (Belgium) 2019
Clans and politics in Kyrgyzstan (PIs: Gani Aldashev, Catherine Guirkingier).

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Teaching Assistant, New Economic School 2018 – 2019
Macroeconomics I & II (M.A. Program)

Teaching Assistant, Higher School of Economics 2017
Microeconomics I (B.A. Program)

FELLOWSHIPS, HONORS, AND AWARDS

- Erasmus Grant, Université de Namur, 2019
- Petr Aven Scholarship, New Economic School, 2018 (academic excellence)
- National and Regional Competition Awards, 2009–2010 (Economics, Social Science, History, Mathematics, Physics)

SKILLS

Econometrics & Programming Stata, R, Python, LaTeX, QGIS

Languages English (fluent), Russian (native), Japanese (intermediate), French (beginner)

ABSTRACTS

Power Without Information: The Human Cost of Uniform Land Taxation in Subsistence Agriculture
[Job Market Paper]

A state that cannot verify the harvest it taxes chooses between a crop share, which invites a reporting game between the farm and the assessor, and a fixed rent per hectare, which cannot be moved by a report of the harvest and cannot follow it: a fixed rent taxes uniformly farms whose harvests differ. In January 1933 the Soviet state replaced its claim on the assessed grain harvest of collective farms with a fixed rent per sown hectare, one rate for every farm of a district. On the accounts of 272 collective farms of the Urals for 1933 and 1934, I measure what uniform taxation cost in people and divide the cost between information and incentives. The sequence of the agricultural year fixes what each party observed when it acted and hence the form of each claim; the rules estimated from the accounts, the district office's schedule, the farm's division of grain between seed and food, the seed relief and the response of population to food, convert any schedule of deliveries into members a

year later. Relative to the same statutory total allocated on harvests with subsistence first, the policy as run cost 4,392 people, one member in twenty-eight: 707 from taxing uniformly farms whose harvests differed, 2,755 from the level of the wedge, the offices' collection above the norm, and 930 from its allocation across farms the office could not tell apart. Relief that came as seed in the spring rather than food in the autumn cost a further 964.

Taxing What the State Could See: The Design of Soviet Grain Procurement and the Famine of 1933

Soviet grain procurement in 1932 was a presumptive tax: the quantity a district owed was assigned before the harvest from its own past deliveries, collected against harvest estimates that exceeded the barn crop, and reducible only by decision from above. Whether that design accounts for collective farms left below subsistence in 1932 and for the regional incidence of the mortality of 1933 is tested in the state's own post-harvest accounts, the district plans and the district death registers. Almost no collective farm grew too little; nine of ten Ukrainian collective farms were left with too little; the depth of the residual predicts the mortality rise between regions and survives every allocation of it beneath the region. After the famine harvest the laws of 1933 fixed both the delivery and the station's fee on bases the state could observe. The schedules refer to nothing but agricultural traits, and the Ukrainian gradient in extraction is not distinguishable from zero once their terms are accounted for; the higher mortality of Ukrainian districts within regions remains, positive under every admissible allocation of food, and its instruments lie outside the quota.

Victory over Peasantry: Extractive Institutions and the Big Push (with V. Gimpelson and P. Castañeda Dower)

Examines how Big Push policies perform under the constraints of extractive institutions. Using novel micro-data from an All-Union audit of collective farms, we exploit the rollout of Machine Tractor Stations (MTS), the central pillar of Soviet agricultural policy, to estimate the impact of mechanization on collective farm performance, state procurement and peasant welfare in the early Soviet command economy. The Soviet-MTS system rapidly expanded technological adoption but failed to realize the full gains of increasing returns to scale technologies; adoption also did not raise living standards, leaving peasants on mechanized farms at or below subsistence levels.

Technology, Contracts, and Coordination: Modernizing Agricultural Supply Chains in Wisconsin Potatoes

Examines how technology adoption and contractual coordination jointly modernize an agricultural supply chain, using the Wisconsin fresh potato industry (2010–2019), where a wholesaler invested in optical sorting systems and then entered long-term marketing contracts with a retail chain. A random-coefficients demand model and a difference-in-differences design show that the sorting technology lowered marginal cost by about 4.6 cents per pound (roughly 10% of the price) and that the contracts added about 1.5 cents to price-cost margins, with the gains reinforced by improved inventory management and reduced spoilage.

REFERENCES

Paul Castañeda Dower, Associate Professor, Agricultural & Applied Economics, University of Wisconsin–Madison. pdower@wisc.edu

Paul Mitchell, Professor, Agricultural & Applied Economics, UW–Madison. pdmitchell@wisc.edu

Guanming Shi, Professor, Agricultural & Applied Economics, UW–Madison. gshi@wisc.edu